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**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)

**Region:** Africa

**Sub Region:** Southern Africa

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**Place Coverage**

!Koi!kom, Central Kalahari Game Reserve, Botswana

**Section Title(S):** 2. Greeting Interaction

Case 5. One evening, an adult man (Hxara:) living in Camp S visited Camp P, and exchanged greetings with 2 adult male attendants. Then an adolescent boy (Tabu:ka) who was lying near the open-air fire called jokingly to Hxara:, "*≠Kai, Hxara:be*". Immediately, Hxara: approached and shook Tabu:ka roughly and even attempting to step on his head. Tabu:ka rolled about on the sand, crying "Stop it! Hxara:!" (*Hxara:e ho: ae*) with his head between his hands. In spite of the violent way in which Hxara: treated Tabu:ka, both of them remained smiling.

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In the above case, the adult man who was greeted by the adolescent boy regarded this greeting as a banter to him, because an adolescent boy primarily has neither right nor duty to greet other people.

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The second type of deviation directly drives from the ground rule that the greeting can be omitted between 2 persons in a close relationship. Even the 2 persons having neither consanguinity nor co-membership with each other can share a consensus that their relationship is close enough to omit greeting, if they frequently meet and interact with each other. When one oversteps this consensus and dare initiate greeting, his or her act might be regarded as deliberate mischief by the other person.

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Case 6. Late one morning, a female visitor from Camp Ns (!kaoba) had been staying in a gathering of residents in Camp S. Another female visitor from Camp M (kju:) approached here, speaking to !kaoba, "You are visiting here, I have collected firewood". After she sat down at a distance of 1 m from one of the resident women, she exchanged greeting with 3 older residents, one after another. And then, she called to !kaoba, "≠Kai". Immediately, !kaoba stood up and approached kju:, sitting in face-to-face proximity to her. These two women exchanged mock blows with each other, laughing cheerfully, Then they began to talk, grasping each other's wrist (Photo 3).

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Judging from the fact that the newcomer woman at first spoke to the attendant visitor, it is supposed that they had a rather close relationship with each other. Therefore the newcomer's intention to greet the attendant visitor in particular implies a sense of banter.

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The common feature to the 2 types of deviation described above is that the 'superfluous' greeting addressed to the inappropriate party causes a joking interaction accompanied by physical contact between the 2 parties. This point suggests that for the San, greeting is primarily a troublesome obligation, which they are willing to save whenever the relationship or context of the encounter permits it. Because greeting is a serious 'ritual' in nature, its superfluous enactment can exert an effect of mocking at the seriousness of the ritual itself.

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(b) Delay: As was demonstrated by the sequential analysis, greeting is usually exchanged at the opening of the "mutual involvement" (Goffman, 1963: 166–178) between newcomer and attendants. In other words, the greeting establishes the "situational presence", "easing the transition between 'unfocused' and 'focused' interaction (Callan, 1970: 114). However, it was sometimes observed that greeting occurred even after the conversation had begun between the visitor and residents.

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Case 7. One morning an adult male visitor came from Camp S, and stood under a tree from which meat of a hartebeest was hung. Two male residents approached him, and they began to talk loudly. Inspecting the

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meat, the visitor commented upon its condition. Four minutes after the beginning of the conversation, one of the resident abruptly called to the visitor, “#Kai”, and the visitor responded to him. Successively, another resident greeted the visitor.

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